

Who are the "sons of God" in Genesis 6?

A working study in the Noble Mind Study method — four sections, NASB-anchored, Scripture interpreting Scripture.

Working draft. Picks up the inductive case from the phrase itself, addresses the strongest objection from Jesus' words on angels and marriage, and acknowledges the limits of what Scripture reveals about spiritual-physical interaction.

01 — What the text actually says

Genesis 6:1-4, NASB:

"Now it came about, when men began to multiply on the face of the land, and daughters were born to them, that the sons of God saw that the daughters of men were beautiful; and they took wives for themselves, whomever they chose. Then the LORD said, 'My Spirit shall not strive with man forever, because he also is flesh; nevertheless his days shall be one hundred and twenty years.' The Nephilim were on the earth in those days, and also afterward, when the sons of God came in to the daughters of men, and they bore children to them. Those were the mighty men who were of old, men of renown."

The Hebrew phrase is *bene ha'elohim* — "sons of the God(s)." That phrase, and its near-identical variants, occurs only a handful of times in the Hebrew Bible. The text itself does not explain who *bene ha'elohim* are. It assumes the reader knows. Which means we have to ask the next question — where else does Scripture use this phrase?

02 — The pattern Scripture gives

The phrase elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible

— Job 1:6, NASB: *"Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them."*

— Job 2:1, NASB: same phrase, same setting — a heavenly council.

— Job 38:7, NASB: *"When the morning stars sang together and all the sons of God shouted for joy"* — at creation, before any human existed.

— Psalm 29:1, NASB margin: *"Ascribe to the LORD, O sons of the mighty" (bene elim).*

— Psalm 89:6, NASB: *"For who in the skies is comparable to the LORD? Who among the sons of the mighty is like the LORD."*

— Daniel 3:25, NASB: Nebuchadnezzar describes the fourth figure in the furnace as *"like a son of the gods"* — a supernatural being.

In every clear use elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible, the phrase refers to heavenly beings, not to a line of human descendants. This is the strongest single piece of evidence in the question.

The New Testament witness

Three independent New Testament passages anchor a specific angelic sin to the days of Noah:

— 2 Peter 2:4-5, NASB: *"For if God did not spare angels when they sinned, but cast them into hell and committed them to pits of darkness, reserved for judgment; and did not spare the ancient world, but preserved Noah, a preacher of righteousness, with seven others, when He brought a flood upon the world of the ungodly."*

The sequence is explicit: angels who sinned → the ancient world → Noah → flood.

— Jude 6-7, NASB: *"And angels who did not keep their own domain, but abandoned their proper abode, He has kept in eternal bonds under darkness for the judgment of the great day, just as Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around them, since they in the same way as these indulged in gross immorality and went after strange flesh, are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire."*

Jude makes the comparison concrete. The angels "abandoned their proper abode," and their sin is set parallel to Sodom — which Jude characterizes as going after *strange flesh*, *sarkos heteras* in the Greek, "other-kind flesh." The parallel only works if the angelic sin was also a category-violation between kinds.

— 1 Peter 3:19-20, NASB: Christ *"made proclamation to the spirits now in prison, who once were disobedient, when the patience of God kept waiting in the days of Noah, during the construction of the ark."*

Spirits, imprisoned, disobedient, in the days of Noah. Three New Testament passages, three independent authors, locating an angelic-sin event in Noah's generation.

The necessary inference

When Genesis 6 names *bene ha'elohim* without explaining the phrase, the rest of Scripture supplies the meaning. The phrase means heavenly beings. A specific group of them sinned in the days of Noah by transgressing their proper domain. The Genesis text and the apostolic commentary in Peter and Jude are describing the same event from different angles.

03 — What the text does *not* do

The text does not explain the *mechanics* of how the union produced offspring. Scripture reports the event without explaining the biology.

The text does not say *all* fallen angels participated. Jude is specific: the ones "who did not keep their own domain."

The text does not confirm that the Nephilim survived the flood. Genesis 6:4's "and also afterward" is most naturally read as a parenthetical note that the term *Nephilim* shows up again

in Numbers 13:33 — where the report describing the giants is itself called by Moses a "*bad report*" (Num. 13:32, NASB), not a confirmed fact.

The text does not use the phrase *bene ha'elohim* anywhere in the Hebrew Bible for the line of Seth, for human kings, or for any group of human descendants. Both the Sethite reading and the royal-dynasty reading require the phrase to mean something the Hebrew Bible never elsewhere uses it to mean — which is precisely the move the Berean method warns against: importing an external category to override the text's own usage.

04 — Answer

Fallen angels.

The Hebrew Bible's own usage of *bene ha'elohim* points there. Three New Testament passages, written independently, anchor a specific angelic sin to the days of Noah. The competing views require the phrase to mean something Scripture never elsewhere uses it to mean.

The Sethite reading became dominant later in church history; the earlier consensus, including most pre-Nicene fathers, read the passage as referring to fallen angels. The shift came not from new textual evidence but from theological discomfort with what the text appeared to say.

Discomfort with what the text says is not a reason to make the text say something else.

Addressing the strongest Sethite objection — Matthew 22:30

The strongest argument the Sethite side has is not the genealogy argument or the godly-line/ungodly-line framing. It is Jesus' words about angels and marriage. This deserves a careful answer, not a dismissive one.

What Jesus said

Matthew 22:30, NASB: "*For in the resurrection they neither marry nor are given in marriage, but are like angels in heaven.*"

Mark 12:25, NASB: same statement, parallel context.

Luke 20:34–36, NASB: "*The sons of this age marry and are given in marriage, but those who are considered worthy to attain to that age and the resurrection from the dead, neither marry nor are given in marriage; for they cannot even die anymore, because they are like angels, and are sons of God, being sons of the resurrection.*"

The Sethite argument from these verses runs: Jesus said angels don't marry → therefore angels are sexless → therefore no angel could ever produce offspring with a human → therefore *bene ha'elohim* in Genesis 6 cannot be angels.

Reading carefully

What Jesus actually said:

- The resurrected *neither marry nor are given in marriage*.
- They are *like angels in heaven*.
- In Luke especially, the logic chain is: resurrected → cannot die → therefore like angels → therefore no marriage. The point of the comparison is *deathlessness*, not sexlessness.

What Jesus did not say:

- That angels are sexless.
- That angels are incapable of any kind of physical interaction with humans.
- That all angels at all times in all circumstances are incapable of any union.

The leap from "do not marry" to "are sexless" is an inference. The further leap from "are sexless" to "could never produce offspring under any circumstance" is a second inference. By the time the Sethite argument reaches its conclusion, it is two inferences removed from what Jesus actually said.

The Jude qualification

More importantly, Jesus describes angels *in heaven* — angels in their proper domain. Jude describes a different group:

Jude 6, NASB: "*And angels who did not keep their own domain, but abandoned their proper abode, He has kept in eternal bonds under darkness for the judgment of the great day.*"

The Greek phrases are deliberate. *Tērēasantas tēn heautōn archēn* — "kept their own domain." *Apolipontas to idion oikētērion* — "abandoned their proper abode." Jude is describing angels who *transgressed their proper state*.

The Sethite argument from Matthew 22:30 implicitly assumes that what is true of angels in their proper state is true of angels in any state, including a state of rebellion. But Scripture does not make that assumption. Scripture treats the rebellion itself as the violation — angels doing what angels are not supposed to do.

Jesus described angels in heaven. Jude described angels who abandoned heaven. These are not the same group, and they are not necessarily under the same constraints.

Where this leaves Matthew 22:30

The objection is real, but it does not reach the conclusion the Sethite side needs it to reach. Jesus' statement about angels in heaven is fully compatible with Jude's statement about angels who abandoned that state. Both can be true at once. The Genesis 6 reading does not require the angels to have been in their proper domain — it requires precisely the opposite, which is what Jude says.

The spiritual-physical question

If the *bene ha'elohim* are angels, and angels are spiritual beings, how can spiritual beings interact physically with the material world to the point of producing offspring? This is a real question and worth treating honestly.

What Scripture clearly shows

Spiritual beings taking physical form is not a stray detail in the Bible. It is a recurring pattern, and the descriptions are specific.

— Genesis 18 — three "men" appear to Abraham. Genesis 18:8, NASB: *"He took curds and milk and the calf which he had prepared, and placed it before them; and he was standing by them under the tree as they ate."* They eat real food. Two of them then walk to Sodom (Gen. 19:1) where they are now called angels.

— Genesis 19 — those same two angels in Sodom are physically substantial enough that the men of the city believe they can be assaulted. The angels grab Lot, pull him into the house, and strike the attackers with blindness (Gen. 19:10-11).

— Genesis 32:24-30 — Jacob wrestles with a "man" through the night. Hosea 12:4, NASB later identifies the figure: *"Yes, he wrestled with the angel and prevailed."* Jacob's hip is dislocated in the encounter.

— Judges 13 — the angel of the LORD appears to Manoah and his wife, perceived as physically present until the moment he ascends in the flame of their offering.

— Luke 24:39, NASB — the resurrected Jesus says: *"See My hands and My feet, that it is I Myself; touch Me and see, for a spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have."* And in Luke 24:41-43, NASB: *"While they still could not believe it because of their joy and amazement, He said to them, 'Have you anything here to eat?' They gave Him a piece of a broiled fish; and He took it and ate it before them."*

The resurrected Christ — the firstfruits and pattern for our own resurrection bodies — eats real fish. The same body also enters rooms with locked doors (John 20:19) and vanishes from sight (Luke 24:31).

What this rules out

The Bible rules out the assumption that "spiritual" means "non-interacting with the physical." That assumption is a Greek philosophical category, not a biblical one. In the biblical pattern, spiritual beings can and do take on physical form — to the point of eating, wrestling, being grabbed, and being seen.

Whatever "spiritual" means in Scripture, it does not mean "incapable of physical action."

What the Bible does not explain

How a spiritual being assembles or assumes a body. Whether the body is permanent or temporary. Whether it has the same continuity as a created human body. The mechanism of

spiritual-physical interaction. None of this is explained.

That asymmetry is itself important. The text repeatedly *shows* the phenomenon without ever feeling the need to *explain* it. The inspired writers either did not have the explanation, or considered the explanation beside the point. Either way, the text's posture is: this is what happens; you don't need to know how.

The future spiritual body

Paul addresses the related question of our own future bodies, and his answer is suggestive without being complete.

1 Corinthians 15:42–44, NASB: "*So also is the resurrection of the dead. It is sown a perishable body, it is raised an imperishable body; it is sown in dishonor, it is raised in glory; it is sown in weakness, it is raised in power; it is sown a natural body, it is raised a spiritual body. If there is a natural body, there is also a spiritual body.*"

The phrase that matters is *spiritual body* — *sōma pneumatikon*. Paul does not say *spirit*. He says *body*. He puts together the two words that Greek philosophy held apart. A body that is somehow *of the Spirit* in nature, but is still *body*. The category is biblical. The mechanics are not provided.

1 John 3:2, NASB: "*Beloved, now we are children of God, and it has not appeared as yet what we will be. We know that when He appears, we will be like Him, because we will see Him just as He is.*"

Paul gives the category. John says the full picture has not yet been revealed. The pattern is the resurrected Christ. The mechanics remain hidden until we are there.

Where this leaves the Genesis 6 question

The spiritual-physical objection treats *spiritual* and *physical* as mutually exclusive. The Bible treats them as distinguishable but not separable. Spiritual beings throughout Scripture eat, wrestle, grab, strike, and appear in forms perceptible to human sight and touch. Whatever mechanism allows that elsewhere is presumably the same mechanism at work in Genesis 6.

What Scripture does *not* explain is how. And that is where the study stops, because going further is speculation dressed as exegesis.

Deuteronomy 29:29, NASB: "*The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things revealed belong to us and to our sons forever, that we may observe all the words of this law.*"

The discipline is to honor the line Scripture draws. The *fact* of spiritual-physical interaction is well-attested. The *mechanism* is not explained. The future spiritual body is real, but its full nature is hidden until revealed. We work with what we have, and we do not pretend to have what we do not.

Summary

The inductive evidence for *bene ha'elohim* as fallen angels is strong:

- The phrase elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible always refers to heavenly beings (Job 1:6; 2:1; 38:7; Ps. 29:1; 89:6; Dan. 3:25).
- Three independent New Testament passages tie an angelic sin specifically to the days of Noah (2 Pet. 2:4–5; Jude 6–7; 1 Pet. 3:19–20).
- Jude's specific phrasing — angels who *abandoned their proper abode* and went after *strange flesh* — fits the Genesis 6 description.
- The Sethite and royal-dynasty readings require the phrase to mean something the Hebrew Bible never elsewhere uses it to mean.

The strongest Sethite objection — Matthew 22:30 on angels and marriage — does not reach its conclusion. Jesus described angels in heaven; Jude described angels who abandoned heaven. The two statements are fully compatible.

The deeper question of how spiritual beings interact physically with the material world is real but not unique to Genesis 6. Scripture repeatedly attests the *fact* of spiritual-physical interaction without explaining its *mechanism*. The same epistemic discipline that applies to Genesis 18, Genesis 19, Genesis 32, Judges 13, and Luke 24 applies to Genesis 6. The fact is reported. The mechanism is not. We accept what is revealed and refrain from systematizing what is not.

■ *"Examine the Scriptures daily to see whether these things were so." — Acts 17:11, NASB*

Notes for future development

Bridge Moments short-reply version (already used)

■ Three readings get defended in this thread, and the cleanest way to test them is to ask where else the phrase "sons of God" — *bene ha'elohim* — appears in the Hebrew Bible. Job 1:6, 2:1, 38:7. Each time, heavenly beings. Then 2 Pet. 2:4–5 and Jude 6–7 anchor a specific angelic sin to the days of Noah. The Sethite and kings views require the phrase to mean something the Hebrew Bible never uses it to mean elsewhere. Let the Bible's own usage decide.

Possible site URL

noblemind.study/test-this-claim/sons-of-god-in-genesis-6.html

Title and subtitle for site publication

Title: *Who are the "sons of God" in Genesis 6?* Subtitle: *A short answer, and the citations that lead to it.*

Structural notes for site publication

The current draft has the four-section spine intact but adds two appended sections (Matthew 22:30 objection, and the spiritual-physical question). On the site, these two could be handled in three different ways:

1. Inline — fold the Matthew 22:30 material into Section 03 ("What the text does not do — the alternatives, and what they cost") and the spiritual-physical material into a closing note. Keeps the page tight to the spine.
2. Companion studies — publish the main four-section study, then publish two shorter companion studies that link from it: *"Does Matthew 22:30 rule out the fallen-angels reading of Genesis 6?"* and *"How can spiritual beings interact physically with the material world?"* Each follows its own four-section spine.
3. Long-form study — publish as one extended study with clearly marked appendices, accepting that this one is longer than most because the question requires more cross-reference work.

Option 2 is probably strongest for the site catalog, because it produces three studies instead of one and lets each address its own narrower question with the full method. The companion studies also become reusable — the spiritual-physical study is relevant to many questions beyond Genesis 6.

Cross-reference candidates for deeper study

— Numbers 13:32-33, on Moses calling the Numbers 13 giants report a "bad report" — relevant to whether the Nephilim reappear after the flood.

— Deuteronomy 32:8 NASB margin / Dead Sea Scrolls reading — *"according to the number of the sons of God"* rather than the Masoretic *"sons of Israel."* Strengthens the case that *bene ha'elohim* was a settled phrase for heavenly beings; involves textual variant discussion that requires its own treatment.

— 1 Enoch and the Second Temple Jewish reading of Genesis 6. Not Scripture, but historically relevant: the fallen-angels reading was the dominant Jewish reading in the centuries closest to when Genesis was written and read aloud. Useful as background, not as authority.

— Pre-Nicene Christian commentary on Genesis 6 — Justin Martyr, Irenaeus, Tertullian, Athenagoras, and Clement of Alexandria all read it as fallen angels. The shift to the Sethite reading came later. Sourcing this carefully matters if claims about church history end up in the site version.

Doctrinal posture

The study does not require certainty on disputed mechanics (how the union produced offspring, whether all Nephilim died in the flood, the precise nature of the angelic body). It states what Scripture states, identifies what Scripture leaves unexplained, and refuses to fill the gap with speculation. The four-section spine handles this naturally: Section 03 ("What the text does *not* do") is where the limits of revelation are honored.

History note worth verifying before publishing

Augustine argues for the Sethite reading in *City of God*, Book 15. His influence on Western Christian interpretation is hard to overstate, but the chain of causation in shifting the consensus

is what historians of doctrine call thick — multiple factors, not just one figure. Before publishing on the site, either source the Augustine claim precisely with the relevant *City of God* passage, or use the softer formulation already in the Answer section: *"the Sethite reading became dominant later in church history; the earlier consensus, including most pre-Nicene fathers, read the passage as referring to fallen angels."* That softer formulation is bulletproof and does not rest weight on a single figure.